



RANG DE BASANTI 2006

Director **Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra**

"I told my sister, who is in New York, that I was making the fifth remake of Bhagat Singh. The first four had flopped. She told me you've got to be kidding." The film's nihilism set off debates and its emotional activism sparked candle-light marches but Khan's flashy DJ was memorable. To use his words, "so nice".

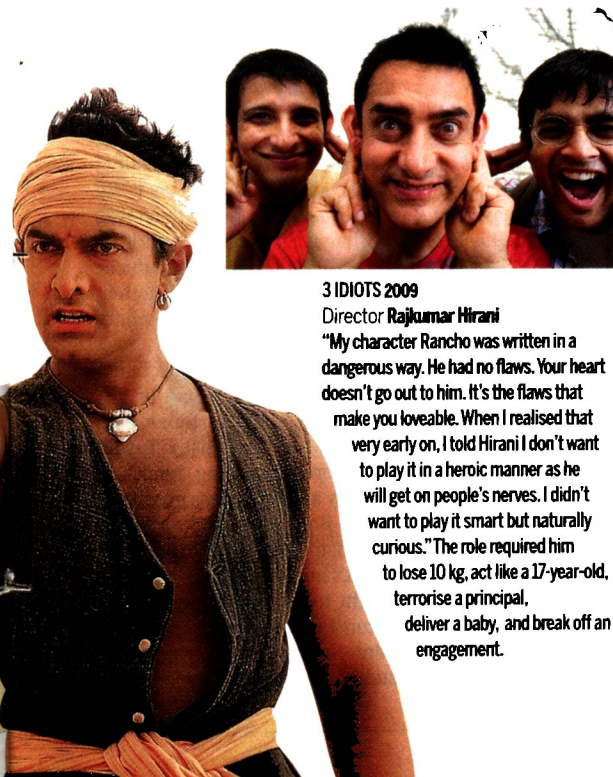
He works with a small but dedicated team which looks for the big idea in every film, using multimedia tools, from Facebook in *3 Idiots* to blogs in *Taare Zameen Par*.



TAARE ZAMEEN PAR 2007

Director **Aamir Khan**

It was written by Amole Gupte who directed it for a week, until Khan, the producer, took over from him. He made a simple story of a dyslexic child into a timely movie questioning the education system, which turned out to be a surprise hit.



3 IDIOTS 2009

Director **Rajkumar Hirani**

"My character Rancho was written in a dangerous way. He had no flaws. Your heart doesn't go out to him. It's the flaws that make you loveable. When I realised that very early on, I told Hirani I don't want to play it in a heroic manner as he will get on people's nerves. I didn't want to play it smart but naturally curious." The role required him to lose 10 kg, act like a 17-year-old, terrorise a principal, deliver a baby, and break off an engagement.

he cheerfully admits to copying from his ex-wife Reena's difficult labour for their first born. And even more cheerfully says he loves talking to interesting new people. "Sometimes I feel like sucking their brains out."

Khan is a star who doesn't play himself in every film, as Amitabh Bachchan did at the height of his fame or Shah Rukh Khan tends to do. He plays the character, which may be why he tends to work with new directors, who help in creating a fresh persona every time. "Audiences now expect an element of surprise from him," points out Kabir. "Like a magician, they want him to conjure up a new character." Once he has identified the perfect script, a director whose vision he shares, and a producer who will back it, Khan surrenders himself to the

moment. There's no spillover, no hangover. Everything apart from the movie goes into soft focus. "When I read a script, it just goes straight to my brain," he says. "It's like a computer in its memory. It just soaks everything in and then it's in my head at all times," he adds, even as he acts out the first part he got in a play in Class XII. It was a line as a painter in a Gujarati play, a role he couldn't actually perform because he was sacked for missing a day of rehearsals. The line remains etched in his hard drive. He repeats it now: "Bloody hell, no one marries me. I wish his mother gets married to a dog."

On the sets, Khan is a trooper. He will hang out even when he doesn't have lines, or just play Scrabble with the assistants. He will promote the film across the country on every media he can find. And he will just not want to go home. Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra, who directed him in *Rang De Basanti*, and has been a friend since, says, "He makes himself completely accessible to the filmmaker." Kunal Kohli, who directed him in *Fanaa*, recalls how Khan was apologetic even asking him for four days off in the middle of the shoot in Mumbai in 2005 because he wanted to get married to Kiran Rao, a highly rated assistant director whose debut feature *Dhobi Ghat* will release this year. "He's there whether it is for readings or costume trials," adds Kohli. "And he's just incredibly intelligent. How many people do you know who can solve the Rubik's cube with one hand?"

Khan calls this quality "obsessive" and regrets that he cannot spend more time with his children, Junaid, 16, and Ira, 11, when he is acting in a film. His cousin, Nuzhat Hussain, a psychoanalyst, who lives in the building next door, has been close to him since he was 10 and she 15. She says the level of professionalism in his work where each person is given due respect is reflected in his personal life as well, where he is fastidious about his honesty. He simply cannot tell a lie. "But he is not superhuman. He does make mistakes. He hurts himself. But he is totally open to learning and feeling new things, which I think is an act of courage," says Hussain. Khan does have self-doubts. Personally, yes, and also professionally. But he refuses to compromise on his